## SECTION IV

### AN ACCOUNT OF FOREIGN PRISONS

I DESIGNED to publish the account of our prisons in the spring 1775, after I returned from Scotland and Ireland. But conjecturing that something useful to my purpose might be collected abroad; I laid aside my papers, and travelled into France, Flanders, Holland, and Germany. I flattered myself that my labour was not quite fruitless; and repeated my visit to these countries, and went also to Switzerland, in 1776.

In the conclusion of my first edition, I made a promise, if the legislature should seriously engage in the reformation of our prisons, to take a third journey, through the Prussian and Austrian dominions, and the free cities of Germany. This I accomplished in 1778, and likewise extended my tour through Italy, and revisited some of the countries I had before seen in pursuit of my object. These observations were published in a second edition in 1780. But before the publication of another edition, I wished to acquire some further knowledge on the subject. For this purpose in 1781 I again revisited Holland, and some cities in Germany. I visited also the capitals of Denmark, Sweden, Russia, and Poland; and in 1783 some cities in Portugal and Spain, and returned through France, Flanders, and Holland. The substance of all these travels is now thrown into one narrative. I have only to add, that, fully sensible of the imperfection that must attend the cursory survey of a traveller, it was my study to remedy that defect by confining my attention to the one object of my pursuit, during the whole of my journeys abroad.

### HOLLAND

Prisons in the United Provinces are so quiet, and most of them so clean, that a visitor can hardly believe he is in a gaol. They are commonly (except the rasp-houses) whitewashed once or twice a year: and prisoners observed to me how refreshing it was to come into the rooms after they had been so thoroughly



cleaned. A physician and surgeon is appointed to every prison; and prisoners are in general healthy.

In most of the prisons for criminals there are so many rooms that each prisoner is kept separate. They never go out of their rooms: each has a bedstead, straw mat, and coverlet. But there are few criminals, except those in the rasp-houses and spin-houses. Of late, in all the seven provinces, seldom more executions in a year than from four to six. One reason of this, I believe, is the awful solemnity of executions,[1] which are performed in presence of the magistrates, with great order and seriousness, and great effect on the spectators. I did not see the process in Holland; but it was particularly described to me, and was similar to what I had been witness of in another place abroad.

The common method of execution for unpremeditated murder, is decollation by a broadsword. Robberies are generally punished by the halter. For the more atrocious crimes, such as premeditated murder, etc., the malefactor is broken on the wheel; or rather on a cross laid flat upon the scaffold. But a description of the manner of this execution, which is finished by a *coup de grâce* on the breast, would not be agreeable to any of my readers.

Debtors also are but few. The magistrates do not approve of confining in idleness any that may be usefully employed. And when one is imprisoned, the creditor must pay the gaoler for his maintenance, from five and a half to eighteen stivers a day, according to the debtor's former condition in life. The aliment must be paid every week: in default whereof, the gaoler gives eight days' notice; and if within that time, the money, or security for it, be not brought, the debtor is discharged.

Another reason is, that the situation is very disgraceful. But, perhaps, the principal cause that debtors, as well as capital offenders, are few, is the great care that is taken to train up the children of the poor, and indeed of all others, to industry. No debtors have their wives and children living with them in prison: but occasional visits in the daytime are not forbidden. You do not hear in the streets as you pass by a prison, what I have been rallied for abroad, the cry of poor hungry starving debtors.

The States do not transport convicts: but men are put to labour in the rasp-houses, and women to proper work in the spin-houses: upon this professed maxim, Make them diligent,

[1] See Note F at end of book.